

Not a Metaphor
By JoJo

I rehearse something clever
while the kettle clicks off.

She leans in the doorway
and clever dies first.

My breathing goes wrong.
Not poetic-wrong—
asthma wrong, like misjudging
a staircase.

Her arm rests on the counter.
A faint knife scar.
I don't ask about it.
I track it.
Already ashamed.

The room begins to pair things:
her silence with my name,
the hum of the fridge with waiting.

She barely moves.
Neither do I.
The space between us thickens,
visible as dust in sunlight.

She almost says something—
stops.

The almost
lands heavier.

I think of a river and immediately hate
myself.
Her knuckle taps the counter twice.
Enough.

What I expect will end
doesn't.
My attention keeps sliding forward,
past manners,
past restraint.

I am no longer deciding
what this is.

I try, once more,
to make her stand
for anything else.
She exhales.
The idea collapses.

Nothing is crossed out.
I stop reaching for language
and stay with the pressure of her presence,
unsymbolised,
unforgiving.
Close enough
that even silence
is contact.

Author's Note
Still not a metaphor.